February 18, 2026

To: Interested Parties
Fr: Impact Research
Re: Polling Shows Virtual Tie Between Independent Dan Osborn and Pete Ricketts

The 2026 Nebraska Senate race starts in a virtual tie. Ricketts begins 2026 in a weaker position than Deb Fischer did in 2024, even after Ricketts spent nearly $2M in the last year attempting to rehabilitate his image. Independent Dan Osborn is seen as caring about Nebraskans and having the back of working people, while overwhelming majorities see Ricketts as putting special-interest corporate donors ahead of what's right for Nebraska. In a mid-term cycle with voters looking to bring change to Washington, Nebraska represents one of the best chances in the country to defeat an incumbent Republican.

- **Despite Ricketts already spending almost $2 million this cycle, the race for Senate is in a virtual tie – 48% Ricketts / 47% Osborn.** Osborn leads in the 1st and 2nd CDs and holds a dominant 65% to 27% lead among Independent voters.

- **A majority of Nebraska voters start with an unfavorable view of Pete Ricketts (46% Favorable / 53% Unfavorable), a much weaker position than Deb Fischer started the 2024 cycle (40% Fav / 42% Unfav).**
    - Rickett's unpopularity transcends partisan labels as he is viewed "unfavorably" by 74% of Independents, 89% of registered Democrats, and more than 1-in-4 (26%) registered Republicans.

    - He's also at double-digit unpopularity in two of the state's three Congressional Districts: -10 in CD 1 and -23 in CD 2. And Ricketts is only +12 favorable in the 3rd District, which Trump won by 54 points in 2024.

- **While Independent Dan Osborn is seen as a candidate who stands with working people and cares about Nebraska, Ricketts is in the red on those traits and also seen as in thrall to his special-interest corporate donors.**
    - A strong 23-point majority identify Osborn as "standing up for working people" and by an 8-point margin feel he "cares about people like you".

    - For his part, majorities of Nebraska voters describe Ricketts as NOT having the back of working people, NOT caring about people like you, and putting special interests and corporate campaign cash ahead of Nebraska. Even Nebraska Republicans believe Ricketts puts his corporate donors (+14) and special interests (+2) ahead of what's right for Nebraska.

- **Ricketts Traits & Characteristics:**
    - Puts his corporate donors ahead of Nebraska: 62% Describes Well / 24% Not Well
    - Puts special interests ahead of Nebraska: 55% Describes Well / 35% Not Well
    - Cares about people like you: 44% Describes Well / 53% Not Well
    - Stands up for working people: 44% Describes Well / 53% Not Well

Findings are based on a poll conducted February 2-5, 2026 among n=600 likely 2026 Nebraska general election voters. The poll was conducted using a mix of live phone and text-to-web interviews. 86% of interviews were conducted via cell phone. The margin of error for the full sample is +/- 4.0%; the margin of error for subgroups varies and is higher.